Warm Up 2: Slot Machine Research
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Visual Design

- Colors:
    - Machines featuring high-contrast color schemes maintain player attention 23% longer than muted color pallets. Warm colors also show higher rates of repeated play compared to cooler tones.
    - Psychological Impacts of specific color choices to player behavior:
        - Red: Usually correlates to increased engagement and decision-making patterns. (IE. Rerolling or making new bets after a loss).
        - Blue: Measurable effects on session duration, linger play times.
        - Gold & Yellow: Ranks highest in player preference surveys when associated w/ reward indicators and win celebrations.
        - Green: positive associations with player confidence, especially in interactive components like buttons (spinning, selecting bet increases/decreases, etc.).
    - Cultural Elements:
        - The use of cultural Elements in theming can maintain player engagement by 40%.
        - Example: Asian Markets
- Change:
    - Features of Wizards, Horse Races, Loud Music, Game Show Characters

Sound Design

- Victory Indicators: Increases in player satisfaction and engagement.
- Interactive Feedback: Response times under 50 milliseconds between button presses and sound create optimal player experience.
- Ambient Audio: Background music matching cultural preferences increases average play session durations by 15%.

Game Mechanics:

- Variable Rewards:
    - Unpredictable reward patterns create more sustained engagement than fixed-ratio systems.
- Near-miss events trigger dopamine responses similar to actual wins.
- # of reels: Three or More symbols that can vary in matching.
- Odds favor the house, players are likely to walk away with less money than when they started. (House advantage average is 8%).

Gamification:

- Levels and Progression: The more a player plays the more features and bonuses they unlock.

- Missions and Challenges: Slots may ask players to hit certain combinations or play for a set time to earn rewards.
- Storylines: Slots could have a narrative that entices players to play to see more.
- Social Elements: Collaboration with others allows for more immersion and interaction while grouping more players.
- Psychology (The Why)
    - Dopamine Rush: Every win, even small ones entice a player to keep winning.
    - Near-Miss Effect: Almost winning can be as exciting as winning.
    - Power of Progress: Progression makes players feel they're accomplishing something even if it isn't monetary.
    - Illusion of Control
- Trends:
    - Virtual Reality Slots
    - Skill-Based Bonus Rounds
    - Personalized Experiences
    - Collaborative Play

Strict Regulations

- Responsible Gaming Code of Conduct
- Prevent Underage Gambling
    - Communicate the legal age to gamble through messaging.
    - If a child is in violation, proper personnel are to be contacted.
- Advertise Responsibly
    - NO false advertising or misleading claims
    - No images, symbols, celebrity endorsements or language that are designed to appeal specifically to children and minors.
    - No suggestions or implications of illegal practices.
    - No promises of financial or personal successes being a guarantee.

UIGEA

- The Unlawful Internet Gambling Enforcement Act
- Payment Regulation: Banks and credit card companies should block illegal online gambling transactions. Transparency of financial records became a requirement of online casinos and gambling companies.
- Penalties: Violation penalties (fines, imprisonment, asset forfeiture).
- Scope and Control: Individual states decide on internet gambling regulations.

The Users:

- Advantage play: Players doing specific strategies in an attempt to increase expected winnings.
- Sour rooters: Individuals who loiter near slot machines in hopes of taking up a machine when it is “ready” to hit a jackpot.
- Four Groups of Players:

- Utilitarian:
    - People looking for something to do.
    - Senior Citizens looking to kill time, reduce boredom or get out of the house, less motivated by financial rewards.
- Excitement
    - Looking for the thrill of winning a jackpot, relaxing and having a good time.
    - Not a fan of progressive machines w/ bigger payouts.
- Multipurpose
    - Younger, Less educated, lower income and less likely to be marred and own a home.
    - Motivated by fun and winning money, attracted to themed games and other machines considered “lucky”
- Relaxation
    - Used for socialization and fun.
    - Stay within denomination usually of 25-cent to $1 machines to relieve day-to-day stress.
- Gender Differences:
    - Women for the social experience, excitement and fun.
    - Men for the financial rewards.

Visual Examples:

ACTIVE SYMBOLS
ALL UP
88 FORTUNES™
GRAND
4,000.00
MAJOR
1,500.00
MINOR
75.00
MINI
40.00
CREDITS
5 GOLD SYMBOLS (88 CREDITS)
4 GOLD SYMBOLS (68 CREDITS)
3 GOLD SYMBOLS (38 CREDITS)
2 GOLD SYMBOLS (18 CREDITS)
1 GOLD SYMBOL (8 CREDITS)
REEL WAYS
BET
X0.02
PER SPIN
BALANCE
1,000.00
STAKE
1.76
WIN

GRAND JACKPOT
999M

MEGA WIN
95.16
GRAND
$5,746.87
MAJOR
$1,137.83
MINOR
$548.48
FREE GAMES
6
MIGHTY DRUMS
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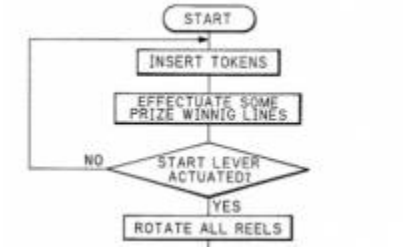
START
INSERT TOKENS
EFFECTUATE SOME PRIZE WINNIG LINES
START LEVER ACTUATED?
NO
YES
ROTATE ALL REELS

Sources:

- The Science Behind Slot Machine Design - Heartwood college of Art
- How Slots Work - GameSense
- The Psychology of Slot Machine Gamification - smartico
- Responsible Gaming Regulations and Statutes Guide - American Gaming Association
- Understanding Online Gambling Laws in the United States in 2026 - Fortis Media
- Reddit
- Study finds slot machine players don't fit stereotype - Oregon State University

Warm Up 2 Persona Document
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Name: Johnathan Shade

Details:
Johnathan is a 64 year old retiree. After a messy divorce he finds that he had won the majority of the possessions he and his ex-wife had fought over and is now feeling overly confident in his luck, as to be frank he should *not* have won that dispute case.

Wants and Needs:
Given this newly found arrogance he decides he wants to take up gambling in the hopes of gaining even more. Even if the odds are low he truly believes he holds all the cards in his favor. All Johnathan Shade wants from his ideal slot machine is a way to go big and go home. If he can bet as much money as he reasonably can he'll likely take it.

Doesn't Want/Doesn't Need:
Johnathan has noticed a lot of slot machines seem to have some payout that is rewarded the more he plays and progresses on a single slot machine. In his honest opinion he could care less about that big loadout, in fact it feels a bit cheap and undeserving if he just has to reach some specific point to get a big win. While he doesn't mind it as much either he also feels he doesn't need to be subjected to these grand themes that clutter up his screen seen in some machines. All he wants is to win and for it to be completely from the luck of the draw.

User Story #1
As a chronic gambler with a lot of money in their hand, I want to be able to be able to place my own bets and have those bets give me massive returns so that when I win the slot machine gives me more money than what I started out with.

User Story #2

As an older gentle-person who’s just looking to play, I want my plays be fast, flashy and clearly communicated to me so that I know for with absolute certainty when I win, when I lost and how close I was to winning to track my chances and see if I should keep going big or change up how I play in the game.